

The Arcane Aether

The Idea

Why are there so many magic items? And why are the people who make them leaving them all over the place?

What if conventional magic users are really just fancy scavengers, and the true wielders of magic are ordinary people exposed to the hidden nature of reality?

In this world, all of reality is made of countless particles called **Aether**. Everything we know and see is simply Aether gathered into different shapes and patterns. Those who glimpse this true nature of reality are called **Arcanists**, and they can command those patterns to reshape reality through thought and imagination.

But every cast exposes the Arcanist to the raw Aether. That Exposure makes them more powerful while destabilizing their own pattern, causing mutations and eventually transforming them into something feared and hunted.

Magic items are a byproduct of this curse. Arcanists can transfer their accumulated Exposure into physical objects, staving off their own transformation while creating relics capable of performing a fixed magical effect.

The Arcane Aether is a rules-light game inspired by Powered by the Apocalypse, Into the Odd, and Shadowdark. The goal is to make character progression happen through choices made during play. Using magic makes you more powerful, but every cast pushes your character closer to losing their humanity.

The Dice

Say what your character intends to do.

Roll 2d6 + the fitting stat.

Casting uses a spell tag instead.

Roll when the outcome is uncertain and failure would change the situation. Otherwise, let it happen or tell the player what it costs in time or resources.

Total	Result
6 or less	Failure: Gain 1 Luck.
7 to 9	Partial success: Your character does it, but there is a complication.
10 or greater	Full success
Double 1s	Critical failure
Double 6s	Critical success

A complication should be a failing forward: the character loses something, ends up in danger, or gets hurt.

Luck Points

1 Luck: Accept a failed roll to take the Luck.

2 Luck: When your character achieves a key goal and you cross it off their list of vendettas.

Max 10 per character.

Players may share their Luck with others.

Spending Your Luck

Cost	Buy
1	Add a dice to a roll or Assist a teammate.
2	Play a flashback that can affect the present.
5	Advance: Increase a Stat or Spell Tag, increase maximum Harm, or gain an Archetype Perk.

Add a dice

Spend 1 Luck to roll 3d6 and keep the highest two.

Assist a Teammate

Spend 1 Luck to assist another character. Explain how you help and add **1d6** to their roll. The active player rolls all the dice and keeps the highest two.

If the roll fails, only the active player gains 1 Luck, but everyone who assisted shares the consequences.

Flashbacks

Spend 2 Luck to play a short scene from your character's past that affects the present. Maybe you bribed the kitchen servant to leave the back door unlocked.

Play the scene and roll if the outcome is uncertain, then return to the present with the result. Costs and consequences apply as normal. The flashback counts as your action for that turn.

Advancement

Spend 5 Luck to:

- Increase a Stat or Spell Tag by 1, to a maximum of +3.
- Increase maximum Harm by 1.
- Gain an Archetype Perk.

Magical casting

1. **Describe the effect:** how big, how long it lasts, and how much damage it deals.
2. The GM sets the Exposure cost using the casting dials.
3. **Accept the cost or reduce the effect**, then roll 2d6 + one relevant Spell Tag.

Casting follows the normal roll results, with these additional effects:

- **Failure:** The cast costs no Exposure.
- **Success:** Take the Exposure.
- **Full Success:** Add a beneficial flourish beyond the intended effect.
- **Double 1s:** Roll on the **Wild Magic table**, adding your current Exposure.
- **Double 6s:** Gain a new Spell Tag related to the cast or increase the Tag used by 1, to a maximum of +3.

Spell tags

Spell Tags represent what your character has learned through casting. Examples include fire, invisibility, healing, ice, mind reading, floating, talking to animals, light, pain, and poison.

Choose one relevant Spell Tag for each cast and add its rating to the roll. Tags do not stack or reduce Exposure. When you gain a Mutation through casting or roll double 6s, gain a new Tag related to the cast or increase the Tag used by 1, to a maximum of +3. If both happen on the same cast, gain this benefit only once.

Casting limits

Mutations allow your body to withstand greater amounts of Exposure. Your safe limit per cast is **3 + your number of Mutations**.

You may cast above this limit. On a success, mark 1 Fatigue for each point of Exposure above your safe limit, in addition to taking the Exposure.

The GM tells you the cost before you roll.

A spell's Exposure Cost

Exposure = Reach/Size + Effect + Duration.

The most basic cast should be at-least 1 exposure.

Reach / Size	Add
One creature or object that the caster touches	1
A medium sized room, a handful of people, or a wagon-sized object	2
Across a field, a building, a street, or a field of targets	3
Barely in sight or beyond it	4

Force and Effect: how hard the spell pushes, hits, or heals	Add
A change without a forceful impact: transform something, make it invisible, or float it gently	1
A firm shove, deal 1 damage, or restore 1 Harm	1
A hard throw, deal 2 damage, or restore 2 Harm	2
A crushing impact, deal 3 damage, restore 3 Harm, or heal one scar	3

Duration: how long the magic lasts	Add
Instant, or up to the end of the current scene	0
A few hours, up to a day	1
More than a day, up to a month	2
More than a month, up to a year	3
Years, but less than a lifetime	4
A lifetime or forever	5

Casting effects have a specific duration and cease to exist once that duration expires.

For instance, if your character opens a portal, transforms someone into a mouse, makes themselves invisible, or causes a boat to fly, these effects will cease to function once the duration of the cast ends.

Damage and healing caused by casting are instantaneous and do not require any additional duration consideration. Similar to a fire, magic may start it, but the fire will continue as long as it has fuel.

Exposure and mutation

Exposure is a little like radiation poisoning. It collects as a character uses the Arcane Aether, letting them reshape the world while it reshapes them.

Whenever a character accumulates **10 Exposure**, they undergo a Mutation. Roll on the mutation table to determine the specific mutation. This mutation permanently occupies an inventory slot. Subtract 10 from the Exposure and retain any remaining value.

If the cast also causes fatigue, resolve the Exposure and any resulting mutations before addressing the fatigue.

Magic Items

Your character can move Exposure out of their body and into an object, making a magical relic.

This is why powerful magic users leave so many relics behind. They cannot keep all their Exposure in their bodies, and they cannot carry every object they fill.

A relic takes **one inventory slot**, holds up to **6 Exposure**, and takes **an undisturbed hour** to create or refill. When activated, subtract the effect's Exposure cost from the relic instead of the character.

Inventory and conditions

Your character has **12 inventory slots**. Gear fills from the top down. Conditions fill from the bottom up, taking the lowest available slot.

An item usually takes one slot. Small things of the same kind bundle together: a handful of arrows, spikes, or three rations. Worn armor is free, as in Character Creation.

Mutations, scars, and fatigue are conditions. If one takes a slot holding an item, that item is dropped. Fatigue can also come from exhaustion or a fitting consequence.

When conditions claim all twelve slots, the character is lost. They become a Demon, lose their form, or otherwise cease to be playable.

Movement

A move shifts your character one zone toward or away from something. You can skip an action to take a double move.

Zone	Meaning
Close	Melee. Close enough to touch.
Near	Across the room. One move to Close.
Far	Two moves. Bowshot.

Combat

Characters act first, then enemies.

Players roll a 1d6, highest goes first.

Clockwise after that.

If the players are surprised they go after the attackers.

Your character's turn

Your character can perform one move and one action on their turn. They can attack, cast spells, catch their breath to regain 1d6 harm, use an item, assist someone, or try something else.

For hand-to-hand combat, roll **2d6 + Strength**. For a ranged attack, roll 2d6 + Dexterity. Your character must be able to reach the target with the weapon they are using.

Attacks follow the normal roll results, with these effects:

- **Partial Success:** Deal the weapon's damage and suffer a complication.
- **Full Success:** Deal double the weapon's damage.
- **Double 6s:** Deal triple damage and ignore armor.
- **Double 1s:** The attack fails. Take 1 damage or your weapon breaks, whichever fits.

Enemies roll attacks using the same rules as characters.

On a failure or partial success, the character may avoid the attack, gain an advantage, or impose another fitting complication. The enemy still completes its turn.

Damage and Armor

Weapons deal damage based on their size and weight:

- **Small or concealable:** 1 damage
- **Normal:** 2 damage
- **Heavy or two-handed:** 3 damage

Apply any damage multipliers from Perks before doubling or tripling damage from the roll.

Armor reduces incoming damage. Worn armor and shields stack to a maximum of **3 Armor**, though legendary creatures may have more.

When taking damage, subtract Armor from the damage dealt. If the damage exceeds the Armor, deal the remaining damage and the Armor breaks. If the damage does not exceed the Armor, no damage is dealt and the Armor remains intact.

A critical success ignores Armor without breaking it. Broken Armor must be repaired by someone with the necessary skills. Pay them or owe them a favor.

When enemies attack

Use the enemy's **Threat** from its monster stats. The GM rolls **2d6 + Threat**.

Total	Result
6 or less	The attack misses.
7 to 9	Deal the enemy's listed damage.
10 or more	Deal the enemy's listed damage and cause a complication.
Double 6s	Deal triple damage and ignore armor.
Double 1s	the attack fails and the enemy suffers a mishap.

A crowd attacking one target rolls once, using the highest **Threat** and best single damage among them. Their numbers can still block exits, surround characters, or create other complications.

Harm, Scars, and Recovery

Subtract damage from your character's current **Harm**. Their Archetype sets the maximum. Harm cannot fall below zero.

When a hit brings a character to zero Harm, mark **one Scar**. Each damaging hit taken at zero Harm causes another Scar. A single hit causes only one Scar, regardless of excess damage.

Each Scar permanently occupies an inventory slot until removed. Healing Harm does not remove Scars.

Healing

- **Catch your breath:** Spend an action and restore **1d6 Harm**. You cannot do this while Fatigued.
- A couple of quiet hours: Restore 2d6 Harm if you have no Fatigue.
- **A full night's rest:** Remove one Fatigue. If none remains afterward, restore all Harm.

Harm cannot exceed your maximum. Fatigue prevents all Harm recovery, including magical healing.

Removing a Scar requires magic or about a week of care from a healer. Removing the Scar frees its inventory slot.

Death and dying

The condition that claims your character's final inventory slot determines their fate.

Final condition	Ending
Mutation	The character becomes a demon-like monster. The Aether has changed them beyond themselves.
Scar	The character's body dies. Their spirit passes on, or lingers because of unfinished business.
Fatigue	The character is taken by the Aether. They have nothing left to hold it back.

The character becomes part of the world's lore, and the player makes someone new. A lingering spirit may still matter, but the character's playable life is over.

Character Creation

Step 1: Basic Details

Give your character a name and a few details about them:

- age,
 - appearance,
 - voice,
 - where they're from.
- A line is plenty.

Then choose a **Life Type** and record its traits. Humans, elves, goblins, cat people, karate turtles, and stranger things all have a place in this world.

Life Type	Perk
Human	Resilient: Can shrug off one fatigue once a day. I Know a Guy: Once per session, declare that you know someone useful in the current location. Share with the table how you know them.
Elf	Foresight: 1 free flashback per session Old Grudge: Remember details from events because you were there.
Goblin	Overlooked: +1 to goes unnoticed. Goblin Friends: If there's a goblin involved, you know each other.
Beastfolk	Such as cat people or karate turtles. Natural weapons: 2 damage with bare handed attacks. Keen Senses: +1 when using one heightened sense appropriate to your animal.
Otherfolk	Choose one body advantage that fits the character.

Otherfolk covers people commonly thought of as monsters, such as crab people, intelligent oozes, lizard folk, vampires, or skeletons. Choose an ability that fits what they are.

Examples:

- A shell or thick hide gives **1 armor**.
- A Lizard person might have a tail they can use as a weapon.
- A vampire might be able to turn into a bat.
- A Skeleton can detach their limbs and reattach them.

Step 2: Choose an Archetype

Your Archetype represents the life your character led before becoming an Arcanist.

Choose an Archetype. Take its starting gear, maximum Harm, and one Perk. Use its suggested Stats or arrange **+2, +1, 0, and -1** across the four Stats yourself.

Stat	What it covers
Strength	Muscle, force, fighting hand to hand
Dexterity	Speed, stealth, precision, ranged attacks
Willpower	Endurance and resolve
Charm	Persuasion and presence

Set your current Harm equal to your maximum Harm.

Archetypes

Type	The character's old life
Hunter	Tracked Arcanists for coin, then woke up as one.
Thief	Lived by wit, speed, and other people's things.
Performer	Lived by fast talk and knowing everyone worth knowing.
Monk	Studied the ancient arts and honed their body into a weapon.
Fighter	Someone paid them to stand in the way, and they never learned to stop.
Witch	Had a place in an order once, then something answered.

If none fit, work with the GM to create an old life. Use the same Stat array and choose starting gear, maximum Harm, and one Perk based on the existing Archetypes.

Step 3: Key Goals

Write up to four **Key Goals** your character wants to achieve. These should matter enough to make them go out into the world and do something about them.

They can be serious or ridiculous:

- Get revenge on the person who killed your mother.
- Burn down the silly hat shop.
- Find out what happened to your sister.
- Buy back the family house.

Choose goals with a clear end. When you achieve one, cross it off and gain **2 Luck**.

Share your goals with the other players. Their characters might share one, want to help, or have a very good reason to keep that hat shop standing.

Magic Items

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Spell Tags

d66	Spell Tags
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The Performer

Lived by fast talk and knowing everyone worth knowing.

Stats: Strength –1 · Dexterity +1 · Willpower 0 · Charm +2

Harm: 6

Gear

- Short sword (2 damage)
- Disguise kit
- A ring of stolen keys
- Padded coat (armor 1)
- Torch
- 3 rations

Perks: Roll a d6, or pick one.

d6	Perk
1	Once a day, you know a guy who can help
2	Once a day, give advantage to any roll
3	Strangers assume you belong here until you give them a reason
4	Once a session, name someone who owes you a favour. They do
5	You can lie to someone who already knows better, and be believed once
6	+1 to any one stat, to a maximum of +3

The Fighter

Someone paid you to stand in the way, and you never learned to stop.

Stats: Strength +2 · Dexterity +1 · Willpower 0 · Charm –1

Harm: 8

Gear:

- Longsword (3 damage)
- Chainmail (armor 1)
- Shield (armor 1)
- Torch
- 3 rations

Perks: Roll a d6, or pick one.

d6	Perk
1	Add your Strength to damage in melee
2	Once a fight, take a hit meant for someone at Close
3	
4	Drop an enemy and you may move one zone at once
5	
6	+1 to any one stat, to a maximum of +3

The Hunter

Tracked casters for coin, then woke up as one.

Stats: Strength +2 · Dexterity 0 · Willpower +1 · Charm –1

Harm: 7

Gear

- Short sword (2 damage)
- Crossbow (2 damage)
- Manacles
- Iron spikes and a mallet
- 3 rations
- Chainmail (armor 1)

Perks: Roll a d6, or pick one.

d6	Perk
1	Can tell an Arcanist by looking at them
2	Add your Dexterity to damage with a bow or crossbow
3	
4	Your doses hold an Arcanist still. They cannot cast until it wears off
5	
6	+1 to any one stat, to a maximum of +3

The Monk

Studied the ancient arts, and honed your body into a weapon.

Stats: Strength +1 · Dexterity +2 · Willpower 0 · Charm –1

Harm: 7

Gear:

- Walking staff (2 damage)
- Bandages and salves (3 uses) - 1d6 healing
- 60' of knotted rope
- Throwing stars
- Torch
- 3 rations

Perks: Roll a d6, or pick one.

d6	Perk
1	Add your Strength to damage with unarmed strikes
2	+1 Armor as long as you can move freely
3	Leap 20 feet and perch on anything that will hold a toe
4	You catch your breath without spending a ration
5	No fall hurts you if you can see it coming
6	+1 to any one stat, to a maximum of +3

The Witch

You had a place in an coven once, and then you were excommunicated.

Stats: Strength –1 · Dexterity 0 · Willpower +2 · Charm +1

Harm: 5

Gear

- A Staff from your old order, 3 charges of an effect. (You did not make)
- Sleep powder
- A bone-handled knife (1 damage)
- torch
- 3 rations

Perks: Roll a d6, or pick one.

d6	Perk
1	+1 to any one stat, to a maximum of +3
2	Gain a spell tag on any double of 4 and 5.
3	Bewitching beauty that give you a +1 to charm
4	You can convert as many common cats to companions as you wish. They do your bidding.
5	Advantage on casting
6	You can build an army from crows that do your bidding.

The Thief

Lived by wit, speed, and other people's things.

Stats: Strength –1 · Dexterity +2 · Willpower +1 · Charm 0

Harm: 6

Gear

- Double daggers (2 damage)
- Leather armor (armor 1)
- Lock-pick kit
- Grappling hook
- 60' of rope
- Smoke pellets (drop one and vanish from sight)
- 3 rations

Perks: Roll a d6, or pick one.

d6	Perk
1	Once a day, slip by without being noticed
2	+1 damage to anything that has not seen you
3	
4	
5	
6	+1 to any one stat, to a maximum of +3

Mutation Table

d66	Mutation
11	Glowing eyes
12	Sharp teeth
13	Long pointed ears
14	Covered in warts
15	Claws
16	Forked tongue
21	Scaled skin
22	Covered in fur
23	Covered in feathers
24	Tree bark skin
25	Metal skin
26	Chitin plates
31	1d6 more eyes
32	Gills
33	Antlers
34	Horns
35	Grow a tail
36	Grow wings
41	Black eyes: see in the dark, hurt by daylight
42	Hear and smell 10x
43	Become a talking house cat
44	Burning Touch
45	Withering touch
46	See-through skin
51	A second mouth
52	A second face
53	Reptilian, cold and slit-eyed
54	Limbs become moving roots
55	Double in size, small giant
56	Shrink to mouse-size
61	Float, never touch the ground again
62	A frozen creature
63	Become faceless
64	Gas form
65	Ooze
66	Come apart into a swarm of bugs with a hive mind.

Wild Magic Table

d66	Magic Items
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Monsters

Four numbers and two words.

Threat, Damage, Harm, Armor, then what undoes it and what it wants. That fits on an index card.

Tier	Threat	Damage	Harm	Armor	Example
Mook	-1	1	3	0	Goblin
Baddy	0	2	6	1	Bandit, Bear
Glass cannon	1	3	3	0	Mummy
Monster	1	3	15	2	Ooze
Horror	2	4	20	3	Demon
Legendary	3	5	30	5	Dragon

Running one

- **Roll 2d6 + Threat** when a monster acts and the outcome is uncertain.
- **Damage** applies to all of its attacks. A bear might bite or swipe, but both deal 2 damage.
- **Weakness** is what gives the characters an edge. Plant a way to discover it: a corpse, a book, a survivor, or someone who has faced the creature before.
- **Desire** is what the monster wants besides killing the characters. Anything with a Desire can potentially be bargained with.
- **Morale:** When a monster falls to half Harm or less, roll **2d6 + Threat**. On 6-, it flees, surrenders, or bargains. On 7–9, it changes tactics or pursues its Desire. On 10+, it holds. Mindless, driven, or bound creatures do not roll Morale.
- **Crowds roll once**, using the highest Threat and best single Damage among them. Their numbers can still surround characters, block exits, or create other complications.
- **Threat +2 or higher:** The monster can attack twice on its turn. Individual monsters may break this rule when it fits.

Legendary Monster

Harm alone never kills a Legendary. Its Weakness is the only thing that can end it.

When a Legendary reaches zero Harm without its Weakness being exploited, it withdraws or changes. If it changes, restore its Harm and make it worse.

Telegraph this from the beginning. Wounds close. Severed limbs reform. The blade comes away clean. Killing the figure beneath the robe only kills the robe.

Goblin · Mook

THREAT -1 · DAMAGE 1 · HARM 3 · ARMOR 0

Attacks: rusty knife, rocks, biting.

Weakness: bright light drives them back.

Desire: something shiny, and to see tomorrow.

Bear · Baddy

THREAT 0 · DAMAGE 2 · HARM 6 · ARMOR 1

Attacks: bite, swipe, bull rush.

Weakness: fire, which no animal will face.

Desire: to be left alone.

Mummy · Glass cannon

THREAT +1 · DAMAGE 3 · HARM 3 · ARMOR 0

Attacks: grasping hands, choking wrappings.

Weakness: fire.

Desire: to punish whoever opened the door.

Ooze · Monster

THREAT +1 · DAMAGE 3 · HARM 15 · ARMOR 2

Attacks: engulf, acid touch, drops from above.

Weakness: salt, or high ground.

Desire: to dissolve and absorb metals.

The Frayed Man · Horror

Too many joints, a second mouth, something moving under the coat.

THREAT +2 · DAMAGE 4 · HARM 20 · ARMOR 3

Attacks: grasping limbs, a crushing grip.

Casts: up to 8 Exposure.

Spell Tags: **Bind · Drain · Mutate.**

Weakness: Hot gossip. He just cannot get enough.

Desire: To kill Steve.

The Last Dragon · Legendary

Ancient · scarred · too large for the ruins it calls home · remembers every wound.

THREAT +3 · DAMAGE 5 · HARM 30 · ARMOR 5

Attacks: crushing jaws, sweeping tail, furnace breath.

Weakness: it must be killed with something that has never been used as a weapon.

Desire: to destroy every surviving account of dragons so no one remembers how to kill one.

